
W+AHT | HOSTED BY CARMEN & SYDNEY



Veterans First Time Home Buying Class

Your step-by-step guide to using your VA benefit & buying your first home

YOUR NAME

DATE

BRANCH OF SERVICE

PHONE / EMAIL

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What Is a VA Loan?

A VA loan is a mortgage loan guaranteed by the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs. It is one of the most powerful home financing tools available — designed specifically to help veterans, active-duty service members, and surviving spouses achieve homeownership.

KEY ADVANTAGE

No down payment required in most cases, no private mortgage insurance (PMI), and competitively low interest rates.

Who Is Eligible?

- Veterans who served on active duty and were discharged under conditions other than dishonorable
- Active-duty service members (after 90 continuous days of service)
- National Guard & Reserve members (after 6 years of service or 90 days active duty)
- Surviving spouses of veterans who died in service or from a service-connected disability

VA Loan Entitlement

Your entitlement is the dollar amount the VA will guarantee on your loan. Most veterans have full entitlement, which means no loan limit — you can borrow as much as a lender will approve without a down payment.

MY NOTES

Pre-Purchase Checklist

- ☐ Obtain your Certificate of Eligibility (COE) from the VA or through your lender
- ☐ Check and understand your credit score (minimum varies by lender; many accept 580+)
- ☐ Review your debt-to-income (DTI) ratio — aim for 41% or lower
- ☐ Gather financial documents: last 2 years of tax returns, W-2s, recent pay stubs, bank statements

☐ Get pre-approved by a VA-approved lender before shopping for homes

☐ Determine your target budget and monthly payment comfort zone

☐ Research neighborhoods, school districts, and commute times

☐ Connect with a VA-experienced real estate agent

Know Your Numbers Worksheet

CATEGORY	YOUR NUMBER	NOTES
Current Credit Score		
Gross Monthly Income	\$	
Monthly Debt Payments	\$	
Debt-to-Income Ratio	%	
Target Home Price Range	\$	
Estimated Monthly Payment	\$	
Cash Available for Closing Costs	\$	

MY NOTES

MODULE 3 | THE HOME BUYING PROCESS — STEP BY STEP

From Pre-Approval to Closing

1. **Get Pre-Approved** — Submit your financial documents to a VA-approved lender and receive your pre-approval letter.
2. **Find a VA-Savvy Agent** — Partner with a real estate agent experienced in VA transactions who will advocate for you.
3. **Shop for Homes** — Identify homes that meet VA property requirements (MPRs). The home must be safe, sound, and sanitary.
4. **Make an Offer** — Your agent submits an offer. You can negotiate seller concessions (up to 4%) to cover closing costs.

- 5. **Under Contract** — The seller accepts. Now the clock starts on inspections, appraisal, and underwriting.
- 6. **VA Appraisal** — A VA-assigned appraiser verifies the home meets MPRs and confirms fair market value.
- 7. **Underwriting & Approval** — The lender reviews all documents and issues a Clear to Close (CTC).
- 8. **Closing Day** — Sign the documents, pay any closing costs, and receive your keys. Congratulations — you're a homeowner!

VA FUNDING FEE

Most VA loans require a funding fee (typically 1.25%–3.3% of the loan amount) paid at closing or rolled into the loan. Veterans with a service-connected disability rating of 10% or more are exempt.

QUESTIONS I WANT TO ASK

MODULE 4 | UNDERSTANDING COSTS & FINANCES

What Will I Need at Closing?

Even with no down payment, there are closing costs to plan for. Typical VA closing costs range from **1%–3%** of the loan amount.

CLOSING COST ITEM	TYPICAL RANGE	MY ESTIMATE
VA Funding Fee	1.25% – 3.3%	\$
Appraisal Fee	\$500 – \$900	\$
Title Insurance	\$500 – \$1,500	\$
Loan Origination Fee	Up to 1%	\$
Homeowners Insurance (1st year)	\$800 – \$2,000	\$
Property Tax Escrow (2–3 months)	Varies	\$
Home Inspection	\$300 – \$600	\$
Total Estimated Closing Costs		\$

MY NOTES

QUICK REFERENCE | KEY TERMS GLOSSARY

Amortization

The process of paying off a loan over time through regular monthly payments that cover both principal and interest.

Annual Percentage Rate (APR)

The true yearly cost of a loan, including interest and fees, expressed as a percentage.

Certificate of Eligibility (COE)

A document from the VA that confirms your eligibility for the VA home loan benefit.

Debt-to-Income Ratio (DTI)

Your total monthly debt payments divided by your gross monthly income. A lower DTI means better loan terms.

Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)

A good-faith deposit made when your offer is accepted, typically 1%–2% of the purchase price.

Escrow

A neutral third-party account that holds funds (taxes, insurance) until specific conditions are met at closing.

Minimum Property Requirements (MPRs)

VA standards ensuring a home is safe, structurally sound, and sanitary before a VA loan is approved.

Pre-Approval

A lender's conditional commitment to lend you a specific amount, based on a review of your financial profile.

VA Funding Fee

A one-time fee paid to the VA to help sustain the loan program. Waived for veterans with a service-connected disability.

VA Loan Entitlement

The amount the VA guarantees on your behalf. Full entitlement means no loan limits or down payment requirement.

NOTES | USE THIS SPACE THROUGHOUT THE CLASS

